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Basic Blues Improv [Blues Riffs]



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Simple blues [riffs](#) are perhaps the most common way for one to begin improvising on the harmonica. Use repetition of a single riff and pauses between these riffs to create a more melodic feeling to your playing. Sound files examples, explanations, and instruction are directly below the blues riffs.

***Please Note-** Our Free Site content includes many of the underlined links in the "gray navigation box" directly above; the other topics are available exclusively in the Members Area. Some links lead to lists of additional content also found in the Members Area.

The complete website with over "425 pages of info and instruction" is available with [Membership at Harmonica Lessons.com.](#)

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2nd position (G on C) 2nd Position Blues Riffs

<u>Trouble Riff</u> 4 5 4 5 6 ↓ ↓ ↓ ↓ ↑	<u>Blues Riff #4</u> 6 5 4 5 6 ↑ ↓ ↓ ↓ ↑	<u>Mannish Boy Riff</u> 2 4 (3) 3 2 2 2 ↓ ↑ (↑) ↓ ↓ ↓ ↓ opt.
<u>Blues Riff #1</u> 2 3 4 4 4 3 2 ↓ ↓ ↑ ↓ ↑ ↓ ↓	<u>Blues Riff #2</u> 1 2 2 3 2 ↓ ↑ ↓ ↓ ↓	<u>"Almost" Blues Scale</u> 2 3 4 4 5 6 5 4 4 3 2 ↓ ↓ ↑ ↓ ↓ ↑ ↓ ↓ ↑ ↓ ↓
<u>Blues Riff #3</u> 4 4 4 5 6 ↓ ↙ ↓ ↓ ↑ b	<u>Blues Riff #4 w/ bend</u> 2 2 1 2 2 ↓ ↙ ↓ ↙ ↓ b b b	<u>Warble (trill)</u> 4 5 4 5 4 5 4 ↓ ↓ ↓ ↓ ↓ ↓ ↓ etc.
<u>Triplet Riffs</u> 4 3 4 6 5 4 4 5 4 3 2 2 ↓ ↓ ↑ ↑ ↓ ↓ ↓ ↓ ↓ ↓ ↓ ↑ (Triplets: all three notes in one foot tap. Emphasize first note each time.)		

- **"Number and Arrow" system of notation**- The "up" arrows indicate blow (exhale) notes and the "down" arrows are for the draw (inhale) notes- The little "b's" under the bent arrows are [flat signs](#). One "b" is a [half step](#) bend and two "b's" are a whole step bend (as shown in the graphic below).

4 ↑ = Blow on Hole 4	4 ↓ = Draw (inhale) on Hole 4
3 ↙ = Whole step bend on Hole 3 b b	

The number and arrow system.

- **All riffs are played in the 2nd position**- For more information on 2nd position, visit the [General Overview](#) section.
- **Use your own timing**- Except for the [triplet riffs](#), you can use your own timing with these riffs to make them fit into whatever song you are playing with. Listen to the sound file below the riffs to help get you started.
- **For Intermediate and Advanced players**- you can add a 4 draw bend between the 4 blow and the 4 draw of the "Almost Blues Scale" riff. This will make it a complete one octave [blues scale](#).
- **"Jam-To" Blues MIDI File**- If you would like a quick, easy background song to begin jamming to, you can use the ["Jam-To" MIDI File](#) in "G" to try out the different riffs and ideas outlined here. Additional MIDI files are also available.
- **CDs to play along with**- You'll also want to take a look at the CDs: Song Keys section which contains a listing of albums with each track "keyed" so that you

will be able to jam to the songs found on it. Most of the CDs can be purchased via our [Store: Buy Music CDs page](#). Beginning jammers will find the ["Recommended for Beginners" CDs](#) page a great place to start.

Click here to learn about the ["Techniques Improv"](#) or ["Target Notes"](#) approach to jamming.

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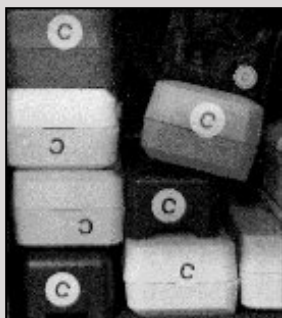
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Welcome to Harmonica Lessons.com. If you are new to this site and/or new to the harmonica, please take a few minutes to look over the above blue-linked "BEGINNERS START HERE" sections before moving on.

- **Do you have a question?-** Virtually every question that has ever been asked by beginners is already answered in these "BEGINNERS START HERE" blue-linked sections above or in the black-linked "RELATED AREAS" sections (to the immediate right). Our Members Area comes complete with a Discussion Forum and Chat Room, where you are able to post your own questions for fellow members and staff.
- **Harmonica is not as easy as it looks-** Harmonica is not nearly as easy as most people would have you believe, but we've tried our best to make learning to play it as simple and straight forward as possible. You'll start with simple techniques and melodies; but stick with it and soon you will graduate to jamming blues, rock, country, bending notes, and sounding like the pros.
- **Follow the numbered blue links above in order-** Not all sections of this website have numbered section page links, but when you see them, as in the gray box above, follow the links in order. You will find that time spent reading through these pages in the proper sequence will get you to where you want to be that much quicker.
- **The complete "BEGINNERS START HERE" section-** is available to full members at Harmonica Lessons.com. In addition to the beginning instruction with Lesson Plans and 'Beginners Shortcuts', you have access to in-depth technique instruction, over 100 Tabs & Song Lessons, Discussion Forums, Blues Improv, Advanced Techniques, Scales and Theory, and more. Click here to [become a member](#) or for more info.

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- **Have fun!**- Don't forget, that's why you picked up the harmonica in the first place. We hope you've just found yourself a new passion to last a lifetime.

You are now ready to move to the first page, [1. Which Harmonica do I need?](#), of the BEGINNERS START HERE section. Read through this page to be sure you have the correct type of harmonica before going any further. If you don't yet have a harmonica, you can also link to buy one from this page.

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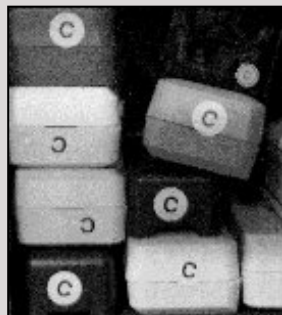
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[1. Which Harmonica Do I Need?]



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You will need a standard 10-hole diatonic harmonica in the key of "C" for the instruction on this site. Double rowed harmonicas (sometimes 8, 10, or 12 sets of double holes) are called Tremolo harmonicas and they along with chromatic harmonicas are not the proper types of harmonicas for our instruction.

- **Key of "C" Diatonic (standard 10-hole) Harmonica-**
You'll need a good quality diatonic type harmonica to learn and practice on. This is what you need for most blues, folk, rock, and country styles. We like the [Lee Oskar Major Diatonic](#) and the [Hohner Special 20](#) (both in the key of "C") best for players just starting out. The Lee Oskar is a bit more expensive, but worth the price for it's consistent volume, tone, and durability. The [Hohner Special 20](#) is one of the best diatonics around for the money. They may not last as long as some other models, but like the [Lee Oskar](#), they sound and play great. (Can't decide? Pick one, and try the other when you need to buy another key.)
- **Will my harmonica work with this site?-** Visit the ["Recommended Harmonicas For Our Instruction"](#) page for lists of the 'Recommended', 'Acceptable', and 'NOT Recommended' models and brands. You can refer to this section, [General Overview](#), for more information on diatonic vs. chromatic harmonicas as well as; some basic 1st and 2nd position harmonica theory, and a "Chart of Harmonica Keys & Positions" for jamming to songs. By the way, quick definitions of harmonica related terms like "diatonic" and "key" can be found in the [Terms & Definitions](#) section.
- **Stick with a basic 10 hole harmonica in the key of "C"-**
Diatonic harmonicas come in all twelve keys (G, Ab, A, Bb, B, C, Db, D, Eb, E, F, F#), but for beginners it's easier if you

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start with a basic 10 hole harmonica in the key of "C" (generally speaking, the "G" harmonicas are very low and the "F" and "F#" harmonicas are very high pitch-wise, while the "C" is right in the middle). Key of "C" harmonicas are the most common, and they also make understanding [music theory](#) much easier.

- **Should I buy other key diatonic harmonicas as well?-** As you improve and begin to play with others or start [playing along with CDs](#), you will want to pick up some of the other key diatonics. The "C", "A", "D", "F", and "G" keys are a good place to start- in roughly that order. The key of harmonica you need is determined by the key the song is in and usually set by the singer. If you are not playing along with other people or with CDs, all you need is a key of "C" for now.
- **Will a key other than "C" work at this site?-** You should note that [all keys of standard diatonic harmonicas are layed out](#) and played the same way. That is, if you already own a standard 10-hole diatonic in a key other than the key of "C" (like an "A" or "D" for instance), it will work for the instruction and songs on this site. But, make the key of "C" your next purchase.
- **A cheap harmonica is tough to learn on-** Prices may vary, but it is best to buy one for no less than \$17 to \$25, because a cheap harmonica can be extremely difficult to learn on. Poor construction of inexpensive harmonicas causes them to leak air and makes them hard to play and difficult to learn important techniques like bending.
- **Avoid these diatonics, and possibly 'upgrade'-** Avoid wooden [combed](#) harmonicas if you are just starting out for the same air leak problems mentioned above. The harmonicas that are included in the 'Book with CD (or Cassette Tape) and Harmonica' packages are not recommended either. These are very inexpensive harmonicas that are included in the package for convenience, but are typically of low quality. If you have any serious intentions at all with the harmonica, you should plan on an 'upgrade'.
- **Should I buy a used one?-** This is entirely up to you. But, we don't recommend it for obvious health reasons, and the fact that a brand new pro quality diatonic is between \$20 and \$30. Also, harmonicas do wear out over time. It's best to start with one that you know is in good condition and plays in tune.
- **Tremolo, chromatic, and "odd" harmonicas won't work with the instruction here-** Double rowed harmonicas (sometimes 8, 10, 12, or more sets of double holes) are called Tremolo harmonicas and they along with chromatic harmonicas (the one with the button on the side) will not work well with the instruction at this site. Visit this page, ["Recommended Harmonicas For Our Instruction"](#), for lists of the Recommended, Acceptable, and NOT Recommended models and brands.

Now that you have the correct harmonica, it's time for some quick [2. Playing Tips](#) to get you moving. There is a ton of detailed information on techniques and playing theory to be found on this site, but these beginning tips will get you

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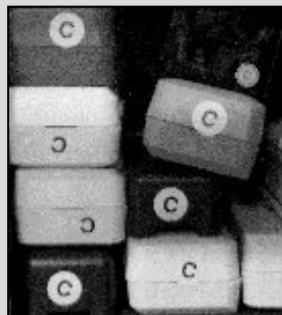
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Here's some additional information that is "Good to Know". For instance, we may not be able to get together with you in person and give you a private lesson, but we can supply you with some tips to help you find someone in your area that can.

- **How can I find a Local Harmonica Instructor-** Admittedly, harmonica can be a very tough instrument to learn without the help of an instructor to give you one-on-one feedback. Unfortunately, there aren't always qualified harmonica teachers available in every area of the country and the world. Here's a few suggestions for trying to locate a teacher in your area:
 1. Call all the local music stores. Look in the yellow pages of the phone book for store listings.
 2. Check for classes at the nearest community college(s).
 3. When visiting local clubs to hear music, seek out any and all bands with a harmonica player and ask if he or she knows someone who teaches or would be willing to teach them self.
 4. Members should try a post at our site's [Discussion Forums](#). Ocassionally, this question is asked and another member will know of a teacher in your area and respond. It's always worth a try.
 5. Still can't find a local harmonica teacher? Fear not, that's why we're here. Follow along, utilize the whole site, and you'll do just fine.
- **What's a Richter Tuning and '12-Bar Blues'?**- You'll be surprised how much you can learn about the world of harmonica and music by just reading through the [Terms & Definitions](#) section. Lots o' good info to be found in there.
- **Jam and practice to MIDI files on your computer-** Our

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[MIDI files](#) page contains play-along 12-bar blues patterns that members can access anywhere there is a computer with sound. The 25 files are in five different keys with different feels and tempos to give you a variety of music to practice and play to.

- **Use Harmonica Store.com for harmonica product info-** If you're wondering what a Natural Minor tuned harmonica is for, visit [Harmonica Store.com](#) and read through it's product description. You'll be surprised how much you can learn about harmonicas and harmonica products by just reading through the product descriptions.
- **Members at Harmonica Lessons.com have access to:**
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At this point, Harmonica Lessons.com Members may want to take a look at the [6. Lesson Plans](#) and [7. Beginners' Shortcuts](#) sections and begin practicing and learning some basic techniques and songs. If you have not yet become a member, [click here for signup info](#).

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